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(1) Research Program/Project/Study Title: Communication Barriers in times of Pandemic	
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Program or Project has component (if no proceed to 2)? ☐ Yes ☐ No

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(7) Sector/Commodity	(8) Discipline/Field of Specialization
Education	Social Sciences/Education
(9A) Abstract	
The study sought to determine the communication barriers among students of Capiz State University, Mambusao Satellite College, in learning during this pandemic. The study used descriptive and qualitative methods. An in-depth interview using a semi-structured questionnaire served as the researcher's data-gathering instrument. Eight students who served as study participants were chosen based on the researcher's criteria. Results showed that students and teachers communicated through cell phones and social media sites like Facebook with the help of the internet. The module-related matter was the primary concern the students discussed with their teachers. The students always started the conversation with the teachers due to their schedules and time availability. Thus, the students discussed only matters they could not understand and asked them in the proper manner. The researchers identified communication barriers include the psychological, organizational, physical, and emotional barriers to communication. Based on the study's results, it is recommended that despite the pandemic, students and teachers must continue to communicate and enhance connection and collaboration. Teachers must promote creativity in the new normal classes, and intervention activities may be conducted to help the students overcome these identified communication barriers.	
(9B) Keywords Communicate, teachers, subject, Barriers	
(10) Introduction	
<i>Communication</i> is a process by which people exchange feelings, opinions, and information. It plays a pivotal role in building a sound and harmonious relationship. It remains the primary recipe for maintaining a healthy working atmosphere between a learner and the teacher. In recent years, the medium used by people to communicate has changed rapidly. Communication technologies have become an integral part of people's lives nowadays. Chaffey (2016), in his social media research, stated that people's social networks are now so well-established that there are already top five social networks that are most popular and which have not changed from year to year, namely Facebook, YouTube, Twitter, Google, and Instagram. Global Web Index (GWI), one of the most reliable research sources of social media statistics, showed that the Philippines had one of the most incredible Facebook users in 2015. Conversely, in this time of pandemic with quarantine protocols, modern technology plays a very significant role in everyday life of every individual. As a well-developed idea in sociology, technology and society can influence each other. That is, technology, to make people's life easier, such as in communication, business, daily life, and now, education. Covid 19 pandemic is the main reason why the Educational System in the Philippines shifts into a so-called New normal education. The Department of Education and the Commission on Higher Education adopted different learning modalities in the new normal education. One of which is the modular learning modality primarily intended for learners who do not have internet connectivity. Printed or Digital Modules are either delivered or picked up by their parents or guardians at designated places within given schedules. Learners under Modular Distance Learning (MDL) use other resources such as learner's materials, textbooks, activity sheets, study guides, and other study materials. According to Bernardo (2020), modular learning is the most popular type of distance learning. True enough, in the Philippines, learning through printed and digital modules emerged as the most preferred distance learning method for parents with children who are enrolled this academic year. This is also prevalent among learners in rural areas where online learning is impossible because of internet inaccessibility. According to a Manila Bulletin article entitled "Understanding the distance learning delivery modalities" (Codamon, 2020), there are 3,885,427 learners in public school who prefer modular modality as an alternative learning option, while about 27 percent prefer online learning; 18 percent, a combination of face-to-face with other modalities; 10 percent, television; 8 percent, other modalities; and 3 percent, radio-based learning (Malipot, 2020). In whatever modality schools implement, teaching and learning require effective communication	

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especially in classroom activities, because it guarantees fruitful learning. However, communication becomes ineffective when there are barriers. The barriers in communication can be physical, emotional, linguistic, psychological, gender, and cultural. Moreover, the examples of barriers to effective communication are one-way and teacher-centered approaches, known to reduce learners' motivation (Dinu, 2015). Other barriers to consider are teachers' challenges in implementing and communicating the modularized instruction. In this aspect, three universities in Ethiopia were assessed in terms of implementing modularization. The results showed that the instructional process in the modularized program was below the expectation level (Dejene, 2019). Another barrier that significant results in effective implementation of modularized instruction are the study of language usage, especially on considerable variation in language use in classrooms that seem dependent on the teacher rather than the students (Brevik & Rindal, 2020). Effective communication between teachers and students is intended to create a positive classroom environment, an element usually inhibited by teachers' failure to engage their students. The result is a situation in which students are forced to unduly struggle to focus on the subject matter (Khan et al., 2018), thus, resulting in ineffective communication.

Communication barriers, on the other hand, as in any communication process, exist in distance education because of the physical distance between members, the difficulties of dealing with new media, time constraints and restrictions, background knowledge of distance education, incompetence in using technology, and the interactivity level in the process (Dabaj & Yetkin, 2011). Put all together; an effective distance education process becomes almost impossible—the significant constraints which halt. Effective communication is a technical and web-based issue. However, as telecommunication systems improve, new types of communication barriers emerge, such as the need for online training and guidance, ignorance of new technology, a lack of satisfactory technology, participants who resist technological change, difficulty accessing the internet, difficulty analyzing teachers' perspectives, and difficulty delivering system (Isman & Altinay, 2005).

However, these barriers may differ in various institutions, programs, and delivery systems used. Preventing these barriers in communication can provide a more evident field of teaching and learning experience between the teachers and the learners. Hence this study.

Statement of the Problem

The study assessed the barriers to communication experience by CAPSU Mambusao Satellite College students. Specifically:

1. How do students communicate with their teacher/s?
2. What issues and concerns do students discuss with their teacher/s?
3. How do students discuss the said concerns with their teacher/s?
4. What are the communication barriers confronting students and their teacher/s?

(11) Materials and Methods or Methodology

Research Design

This study used the descriptive method for narrative research inquiry. According to Aggarwal (2008), descriptive research is devoted to gathering information about prevailing conditions or situations for description and interpretation. This research method is not simply amassing and tabulating facts but includes proper analysis, interpretation, comparisons, and identification of trends and relationships.

A qualitative approach was employed in the study to deal with each student's stories for having a modular mode of learning. Qualitative researchers are interested in understanding the meaning people have constructed, that is, how people make sense of their world and the experiences they have in the world (Merriam, 2009).

The study participants were identified using a purposive sampling method based on the following criteria: (a) currently enrolled in CAPSU MSC; (b) willing to participate in the study. There were eight participants included in the study. The researcher asked for their permission before they were considered as participants. Moreover, their identities are not exposed.

Computer data analysis was also utilized with the use of NVivo12. NVivo12 is a qualitative data analysis (QDA) computer software package produced by QSR International. It has been designed for qualitative researchers working with rich text-based and/or multimedia information, where deep levels of analysis on small or large volumes of data are required.

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Ethics and informants' safety are particularly emphasized in any research work. Accordingly, utmost care will be used to ensure the anonymity and safety of participants. Participants in this study were informed through informed consent of the anonymity of their identity, about the research goals, and that they could skip questions or stop at any time.

(12) Results and Discussions

The following are the results of the study.

How Students Communicate with their teachers

Themes	Significant Statements
Use of Facebook Messenger	1. Students communicate with their teachers using social media and other messaging tools. 2. Students and Teachers interact through their messenger group chats.
Use of interactive platforms	1. Students use messenger, email, and SMS to send personal messages to their teachers. 2. Teachers' contact information where students can seek consultation or can queries through phone calls, text messaging, and social media platforms are evident in their respective course syllabus. 3. Students and teachers communicate thru Facebook groups, messenger, email, and google Classroom.

The use of Facebook messenger was the prominent theme. The theme was supported by significant statements that were ferreted from their responses. Results revealed that most students usually communicate with their teachers through Facebook messenger since it was the first social media tool available and is commonly used by many nowadays. As one participant stated, *"I am communicating with my subject teachers through a messaging app during modular learning since it's easy to reach them."* All participants said that their teachers, together with their classmates, had group chats where they could discuss concerns regarding their subjects. Using these available tools during the pandemic, teachers could communicate with their students individually and in groups through group messages or chats.

The second theme that resulted from the analysis was the use of interactive platforms. This was supported by significant statements generated from the participants' responses. The students were given supplemental activities, further readings, and other social media sites to understand the lessons better. Students and teachers interact through Facebook groups, messenger, email, and google Classroom. Results further revealed that students could communicate through Phone calls, text messaging, email, and social media platforms, whichever is accessible. These tools enabled the students to send queries and raise issues and concerns they wanted to convey. As one of the participants shared that *"I communicate with my teachers through chatting with the use of Facebook and messenger. My teachers sometimes make time and effort to discuss issues and concerns regarding our modules."* With this, the researchers saw that the teachers tried to stay connected with their students even in modular learning despite this pandemic. This supports the claims of Moore, 1990 as cited by Natividad, 2021 that Teachers should be in charge of guiding, supporting, and encouraging students to build knowledge in order to meet the demands of the distance education course, as well as to develop learner autonomy so that learners will be able to achieve their goals.

Dabaj and Yetkin (2011) claimed that institutions offering distance education try and find the most effective program and make sure that it is an adequate replacement for face-to-face instruction. Thus, based on the previous themes derived from the aforementioned significant statements, it can be inferred that technology through computer-mediated communication as the means of communication plays a vital role in this new normal education. Kinross (2000) reflected that technology breaks down all barriers by facilitating easier use of knowledge and creating commonplace for everyone. It is also reflected that technology has become representative, creating homeschooling rather than unique learning under the dimension of flexibility. Tananuraksakul (2018) investigated Facebook Messenger as a medium of academic consultation between teachers to students. He concluded that students have a positive attitude towards Facebook Messenger as a medium of scholarly discussion that positively affects the body and mind with confidence, convenience, less travel time, and saving money. Furthermore, he added that Facebook Messenger could be used as a medium of academic learning

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since the students are digital natives. This supports the present study's claim that Facebook Messenger is the easiest way to communicate with students in modular education.

Issues and Concerns Students Discussed with their teachers

Themes	Significant Statements
Submission of Modules	1. Students inform their respective teachers if they cannot submit their modules in the given time. 2. Students communicate with their teachers if they cannot finish their modules.
Lessons Clarification	1. Students discussed with their teachers some topics they could not understand. 2. Students communicate with their teachers to clarify instructions in their modules. 3. Some modules do not have clear instructions and explanations, so students have difficulty answering them.

Results revealed two significant statements, which state that: Students inform their respective teachers if they cannot submit their modules in the given time, and Students communicate with their teachers if they cannot finish their modules, comes up with the theme submission of modules as one of the issues and concerns discussed by the students to their teachers. Most participants are away from school and mostly live in rural areas. They often communicate with their teachers on how they could submit their modules. As one participant shares, "*[I] message my teachers every submission of answer sheets since I cannot go to school to submit it personally.*" Some participants also deal with time management and other home-related activities, so they cannot submit their modules on time. As it states, "*Sometimes I ask for the extension of submission time because I have not yet finished my modules.*" Teachers are constantly supporting and catering to the needs of the students despite the distance. This agrees with the statements of Khan, 2018 who states that students' success is directly related to the effective communication of the teacher.

Another theme brought from the results is the Lessons Clarification. Significant statements support this theme: Students discuss with their teachers some topics they cannot understand very well; Students communicate with their teachers to clarify instructions in their modules; Some modules do not have clear instructions and explanations, so students have a hard time answering them. It could be seen that most of the students' teachers' conversation is about lesson clarification. As one participant stated, "*[I] am communicating with my subject teachers if there is ambiguous direction, confusing typo errors, and activities that have not been explained well; so that I can understand and answer my module correctly.*" Further, All participants said that they usually communicate with their teachers when they cannot understand some of their modules. Almost all of them had the same experience. Students also adapted to the situation they had.

Regarding the concerns that were asked of them, most of them are module-related concerns. As one participant shared, "*[I] communicate with my subject teachers in such time that I do not understand the tasks given to us. Also, it is an effective way to get along well with our teachers, making an effort to learn, and they will be able to give more help.*" The researchers saw that the students were still eager to learn despite the pandemic. Teachers managed interactions to improve students' knowledge to reduce the transactional distance in modular learning.

On the other hand, students are free to ask for clarifications regarding the instructions given in their modules or the learner's packets. Chen and Jones (2007) found distance learners to be better prepared and more active when asking questions than their counterparts participating in traditional classes. Students learning remotely also perceived group work as more satisfying and regarded related communication and decision-making processes as more effective (Jones & Chen, 2008). Researched distance learners were also found to have more autonomy in self-paced learning and to be more responsible for the learning process (Abraham, 2007). Therefore, the distance learning approach promotes student-centered pedagogy and prepares students for ongoing self-learning, which is necessary for professional development and mobility in the labor market.

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How Students Discuss their Concerns with their Teachers

Themes	Significant Statements
Respectful Manner	1. Students discussed with concerns in a proper manner. 2. Being respectful and polite was instilled in students. 3. Students are hesitant to ask.

Respectful Manner is the only theme that emanates from this problem with significant statements that follow: Students discussed concerns properly; Being respectful and polite was instilled in students, and Students are hesitant to ask.

It was discussed that the students communicate with their teachers, especially if they have concerns regarding their modules. However, the limited time with each other made the students say the important matters only. The participant states, *"Well, I always tell the issues directly to the point because I do not want to waste their time, and most importantly, I never forget to speak in the right manner."* Another participant stated, *"[I] usually sent a chat message in the messenger app. [I] start with a greeting, and then explain my concerns."* This simply shows that the students' respect for their teachers was still there by the Manner message and reply to every question. As other participants share, *"As a student, I observe proper ways/ attitude of messaging to my teachers. I let them know what is my intentions of chatting them providing and explaining all the details of my concerns."* Students still treat their teachers with politeness, considering that it is one of the values instilled in us by our parents since childhood; it is one of the Filipino values that are still present. One of the participants stated that *"[I] usually discuss the said issues by approaching them with respect, being wary of the words that I use, and just asking them my concerns without forgetting our relationship as a student and teacher."* It could be seen that student and teachers established a meaningful and respectful relationship. However, sometimes, students are hesitant to ask questions to their teachers. As one participant shared, *"There are many things I want to discuss, but I am shy, and the main reason is that we are trying to avoid misunderstanding, especially that we are graduating."*

With this, the researchers saw the difference between face-to-face communication from mediated communication. It can be derived from the statement that two people communicating in a mediated communication can make excuses if they are shy to ask the person they are talking with. On the other hand, although it could still occur in face-to-face communication, there is little chance that it will happen because you are talking face-to-face, and you cannot easily find excuses to end your conversation. Chen et al., 2012 stated that Online communication and collaboration require typing the responses and explanations and can take considerably more time and be less effective in some cases. Written messages must be carefully constructed to avoid sending an undesired message or unintentionally offending the recipient, which often takes more time than a conversation. Communicators ought to take great care when expressing their thoughts to avoid the unintended consequences of the communication. Finally, generational differences in collaboration and communication tendencies may appear. On the other hand, Rawat, 2015 claims that both verbal and non-verbal communication is vital for the complete transfer/understanding of the content. However, when it comes to the teaching-learning processes, verbal communication plays a much more vital role in the transfer of knowledge because teachers with good communication skills will create a more successful teaching and learning ambiance for the students.

Communication Barriers confronting students and their teachers

Communication Barriers	Themes	Significant Statements
Psychological	Busy Schedule	1. There is a conflict between the students' and teachers' schedules.
Organizational	Availability of Communication Mediums	1. Students have Poor internet connection and only Limited communication resources.
Physical	Proximity	1. Most students live in rural areas and far-flung barangays.
Emotional	Repressed Feelings	1. Students are hesitant to communicate with their teachers.

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The need to maintain quality education despite the pandemic merely inflicts communication gaps between teachers and students as they tried to maintain connections through computer-mediated communication, but being physically apart still produced communication gaps. Based on the study results, Psychological, Organizational, Physical, and emotional barriers were the communication barriers confronting students and their teachers. These communication barriers were identified based on the generated themes of the study, supported by significant statements created from the participant's responses.

Busy Schedule is the first theme generated from the significant statement that there is a conflict between the students' and teachers' schedules. The communication of the students with their teachers dwindled due to the busy schedules of the latter. Since teachers are busy with other school work, they do not all the time can communicate with their students and cater to their needs. As one participant stated, *"Sometimes they are busy and offline to chat, so I need my patience to wait for asking about the said issues and concerns in my modules."*

This communication gap can be considered a lack of attention under the Psychological Barriers of Communication. The lack of attention states that as the receiver of the message is preoccupied with some other important work, he/she cannot focus on the conveyed message towards him/her. It was greatly bestowed in the students' current situation towards their teachers/ in fact, and theirs were more complicated than the implicit explanation of the communication barrier because the communication between them was not happening when it was supposed to happen.

Time constraint is also a result of the busy schedules of the teachers. Teachers and students only communicate for less than an hour, and it is more than one lesson clarification. *"[I] just wait for my teacher/s to reply to my message. Mostly when they are busy, it takes an hour or a day."*

From those mentioned earlier, it can be inferred that communication can be successful if both inferred that a communication process was able to convey their messages as they want their message to be perceived. Thus, it can be achieved if sufficient time is allotted for the students and teachers to communicate. This conforms with the study of Perreault, Waldman & Alexander (2002), which states that the common barrier reported by distance-learning students is the lack of face-to-face interaction with the professor and other students. On the other hand, e-mail becomes problematic because of expecting immediate feedback. In addition, support centers are considered the main factor in enhancing distance-learning courses. In overcoming troubles in the delivery of online courses, involving access to resources in the process, students' communication with the instructor and other students plays a significant role in fostering qualified communication. Further, Marks, Sibley, & Arbaugh, 2005 in their study on "A Structural Equation Model of Predictors for Effective Online Learning," highlighted that the interaction between teacher and student is most important, doubling that the interaction between student and student; and also, some interaction between student and content is significantly linked to perceived learning.

Another theme generated from this study is the availability of communication mediums supported by a significant statement that students have Poor internet connections and only limited communication resources.

Capiz is situated in a rural area, with minimal access to communication mediums. The students and teachers face several communication interferences as they convey messages or transmit information to each other. It could be seen that the most common dilemma during the communication process was the poor internet connection in the place. Even though it was a progressing province, and most of the students' houses are situated on high lands, they still cannot establish a good internet connection, which significantly interferes with their conversation or even interrupts it. One participant said, *"Most of the time, I need to go to our rice field just to find a signal."*

As of 2015, the Philippines has the slowest internet speed in Southeast Asia and one of the slowest in Asia. Not only is it one of the slowest, but it is also one of the most expensive in Asia. It was also found that the growth of the Internet in the Philippines was hindered by many obstacles, including unequal distribution of Internet infrastructure throughout the country, its cost, and corruption in the government. It is also one of the most expensive in Asia.

Another dilemma that some students encountered was that they were not provided with the communication mediums like laptops and android phones; thus, the chances to talk with their teachers became limited. In return, they only use what communication medium is available in their house to

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maintain communication with their teachers. As one participant claimed, *"[I] hesitate to join particularly in discussion or meeting through virtual/online is most difficult in a given time because you do not afford to buy load. It is a poor thing. We do not have laptops at home; when I communicate with my teacher, I just borrow the cellphone of my older sister."*

This communication gap falls under the organizational facilities of the organizational communication barrier. This entails how an organization's availability and sufficient facilities can significantly contribute to timely and clear communication. Therefore, the absence of these facilities can lead to meaningless communication. The findings of (Khanna & Prasad, 2020) showed that most people faced internet challenges and did not know how to use and solve technology-related issues.

Further, another theme generated is proximity. This is supported by the significant statement stating that most students live in rural areas and far-flung barangays. The geographical distance between the students and their teachers undermines their communication. Despite the communication mediums they use to have conversations with one another, it does not replace the closeness the students feel when they are talking together. They are always longing to talk with their teachers face-to-face. One participant states, *"During face-to-face, we can get the response immediately, especially when we need it, but now that we have to do it online, it takes time because all of our subject teachers are busy with their respective duties."*

The physical presence of the person who is saying the message to the receiver dramatically contributes to the effectiveness and realness of the message. With computer-mediated communication, although it serves as the student's way of maintaining their relationship with their teachers, the students still cannot feel the presence of their teachers with the conveyed messages towards them and while they are communicating. This is supported by the statement from one participant that *"Compared to online, face to face is the most effective in consulting our concerns to our teacher. It allows us to quickly exchange ideas between students and a teacher. While online, it takes a minute or hours until our concerns will be responded because of the busy time of both students and teachers."*

Although computer-mediated communication aided the students and the teachers in reaching out to one another, it still cannot substitute for the feeling of conversing face to face. The closer the distance, the higher the possibility of interaction; the farther the distance is, the lesser the interaction can occur. Proximity, therefore, is a Physical Barrier to Communication. This communication barrier implies that as long as there is an existing hindrance between the two people involved in the communication process, communication is not as effective. Considering that it is one of the significant communication barriers, it is also a factor in building communication gaps between the students and their teachers. Keegan (1986) stated that a critical link in communication in distance education was missing, caused by the geographic separation between students and teachers. However, Keegan believed it was the educational institution's responsibility to compensate for the communication barriers to reduce student dropout and help students integrate their academic and social experiences with their education. The discussion of communication barriers to distance education is mainly topical, but at the same time, it is chronological to a large degree.

Further, as the lack of communication continues due to their various interferences, students tend to keep their feelings instead. Since the student is all in the stage of maturity, the researchers observed that they could understand the situation and adapt to this new normal education. The students remained silent about some problems they encountered and were hesitant to communicate with their teachers. Hence the theme of repressed feelings was generated. As the participant states, *"There are times that I feel shy about initiating a conversation with them, or sometimes I struggle to ask help to them that is why instead of asking I prefer to base on my understanding although the topic was not clear to me."*

From the statement above, the researchers can say that students tend not to say things directly and not to share problems because they are too shy to discuss some personal academic-related matters with their teachers. This falls under the emotional barriers of communication; if someone does not feel good, they will likely speak less or negatively. A mental limitation prevents you from openly communicating your thoughts and feelings. It can prevent you from being authentic as it affects your emotions and feelings.

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(13) Conclusions and Recommendations

Conclusions

The following conclusion attained from the following interpretations and findings of the research were as follows:

1. Students and teachers communicate through cell phones and social media sites like Facebook with the help of the internet.
2. Module-related matter was the primary concern the students discussed with their teachers.
3. The students always started the conversation with the teachers due to the availability of their schedules and the time. Thus, the students discussed only matters they could not understand and asked them correctly.
4. Communication barriers identified by the researchers include the psychological, organizational, physical, and emotional barriers to communication.

Recommendations

Based on the conclusions, the following recommendations have been made:

1. As universities generate new instructional methodologies, they should continue communicating with students broadly. Institutions should consider ways of reaching out to students to address their educational needs.
2. It is highly recommended that the institution must give support to the students. The institution can design intervention activities that could help the students overcome these identified communication barriers of students.
3. Further studies may be conducted along this line and focus on the other aspects of communication barriers in the university that would make a better outcome and solution for the problem.

(14) Output (Indicate the specific products, processes or services which the project has produced; quantify when possible.)

This study served as the baseline of Capiz State University- Mambusao Satellite College in finding means to produce modular learning coupled with technological innovations.

(15) Technology Transfer Activity Conducted (Indicate the specific products, activity design, processes or services transferred as extension activities)

Recently, the faculty underwent training on audio-visual preparations using MS Powerpoint and screen recording, and Podcasting using OBS Studio that could help students and teachers utilize their time and knowledge to achieve goals and make modular teaching-learning easy.

(16) Economic Analysis (This should present the direct cost of project implementation, expenses in the production of technology, revenues generated from technology produced, return on investment (ROI) and payback period.

(17) Acknowledgments

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